SOCIETY & TRENDS

The Age of Her Choice

INDIAN WOMEN ARE MARRYING LATER THAN EVER. HERE'S WHY IT MATTERS

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ACROSS INDIA, the age at which women are marrying is steadily rising—and, with it, the contours of health, education and family life are changing. The latest Sample Registration System (SRS) Statistical Report 2023 puts the average marriage age for women at 22.9 years, up from 22.7 in 2022 and 19.3 when it was first recorded in 1990. Earlier, the National Family Health Survey-5 (2019–21) found that 23 per cent of women aged 20–24 had married before 18—a sharp drop from 38 per cent in 2005–06. Yet UNICEF's analysis of the same survey underlined a stubborn divide: girls from rural and low-income families still face the highest risk of early marriage. SRS 2023 offers a much more optimistic picture, even if progress remains uneven. Here are its chief findings.

WHY LATE MARRIAGE MATTERS FOR WOMEN

- Delaying marriage translates to **fewer adolescent pregnancies** and safer deliveries
- Gives girls two to four **more years in school or training**, improving their future earnings and maternal health
- **Lowers stunting and under-five mortality** among children through planned, spaced pregnancies